to name me. But now I just could not stand the proximity of these creatures with whom I was forced to travel to a court.

I had told M L Sharma that I had never met these women, I remembered, but why did he not crosscheck this with the women in my presence? I had an urge to ask Sharma to do it then and there, but I stopped myself. Later when I realised the professionalism of Sharma and his CBI colleagues, I had only praise for the way they dealt with the case.

In the court room, the magistrate pointed to the CBI officials and asked me, 'Do you have any complaint against them?'

I said 'no.'

Since there was no representative of either the Kerala Police or the Intelligence Bureau in the court, I took the question as whether I had any complaint against the CBI officials who had produced me in front of the magistrate. This was later misinterpreted by the Kerala police to be presented as if I have no complaints about the state police, IB or the CBI.

The CBI told the magistrate that they wanted to take us, all the accused, to Ernakulam, as it was getting difficult to question us in Trivandrum were the media was on an overdrive. For this we had to be produced before the Chief Judicial Magistrate court in Ernakulam. The court readily agreed.

SARABHAI: AN ERA ENDS

'We came together from Bombay and he returned alone, in a body bag.'

Having got Sarabhai's green signal to sign the contract to dismantle and take home the Rolls Royce hydraulics lab, I was at the YMCA in London on 30 December 1971 when BBC flashed the news: 'Eminent Indian astrophysicist Vikram Sarabhai was this morning found dead in a hotel in Kovalam in south India.' I reread the scroll to make sure that I had got it right. It was at first unbelievable, then unacceptable to me. I dialed the BBC, which confirmed the news.